

Emerging Telecom Technologies

IMS: IP multimedia subsystem

HSDPA: High-speed downlink packet access

MVNO: Mobile virtual network operator

IPv6: Internet protocol version 6

4G: 4th generation mobile networks

However, he adds, "The overall solution typically involves several other related applications that help in provisioning, managing, billing or monitoring services."

This application development and maintenance opens up an opportunity for application developers with strong programming skills in database, GUI development and so forth. Other aspects that complete the ecosystem are customer support and sales, which can be met with graduates having the right level of skill or training.

Telecom sector can also be broadly classified into enterprise (service providers) side and consumer side. Talking about the enterprise side of telecom, Revuru says, "Engineers with IT, computers and electronics background will have an edge in this domain due to their knowledge of computer architecture and systems design."

Shifting focus towards the consumer side, he adds, "If one is to work on the development of VAS, the minimum qualification could just be any three- or four-year degree. If one is a teen developer, he could be an independent app developer and sell applications in app stores."

Every industry requires people from all backgrounds to come together and work. "At Maveric, we believe that it certainly requires technical graduates with an aptitude for testing to shine in this industry. With experience we have found that we can absorb a percentage of non-technical graduates very effectively but the average person for the kind of work we do needs a technical background," says Parthasarathy.

Opportunities for freshers

Freshers are always a major chunk of the recruiting plan in any industry.

Telecom companies have been recruiting freshers over the years.

Sharma says, "Freshers are usually put through a mentoring system where they get help from a senior colleague to ramp-up quickly and to understand the nuances. In addition, they go through several orientation programmes to introduce them to the corporate environment and technical trainings to equip them with right skills and knowledge. In most cases, the freshers learn on-the-job with the help of a senior mentor."

Given the current growth rate and looking at the future prospects, there are abundant opportunities for freshers in this sector.

"If a fresher is being allocated to the development team, he would definitely be involved in coding, where it is essential to have knowledge about programming languages. But if he is allocated to testing team, he would be involved with testing of software to ensure that whatever is being developed is free of bugs and giving the desired results," says Majeed.

There are various kinds of jobs available for those who install and maintain telecom hardware as well. Some of these jobs are lumped into the category of telecommunications technicians.

Talking about Maveric, Parthasarathy says, "We specialise in lifecycle assurance, which requires us to support clients across the IT adoption lifecycle. Therefore we expect all our associates to be well grounded in the testing processes and in the domain."

Freshers are always a major chunk of the recruiting plan in the telecom industry. It certainly requires technical graduates with an aptitude for testing to shine in this industry

Adding to Maveric's grooming process, he says, "We invest in our people and have a long-term perspective in our interaction with them. Grooming from a scratch is therefore important. A fresher would, after receiving the initial training, be associated with a mentor so that he/she can be guided on the domain, testing and people interaction skills gradually."

Variety of job roles

Freshers can be absorbed across verticals depending on the business requirements. Talking about the entry-level roles, Khan says, "It can vary from a management trainee to an executive of any vertical existing today in the telecom sector. Freshers can join a business process outsourcing (BPO) unit, knowledge process outsourcing (KPO) unit, sales, marketing, HR, product development, R&D, relationship management, software and hardware engineering depending on their educational background and interests."

Talking about his experience in the telecom sector, particularly managing enterprise products and customers for the last 16 years, Revuru says, "The biggest challenge I face with fresher engineers is while developing products for enterprise customers, which is an entirely different ball game from perceived 'cool' apps development." He adds, "Though it takes four to six months for an engineer to start being productive, it takes one to two years to really appreciate the challenges and technology in the telecom domain."

Pay package

Telecom engineers over the years can gain domain knowledge and continue to build their career. The entry barriers in the telecom domain (enterprise) are high.

"This ensures that the number of entrants in this domain is limited and one gets benefitted during the increasing demand cycle," says Revuru. "The typical pay package would be